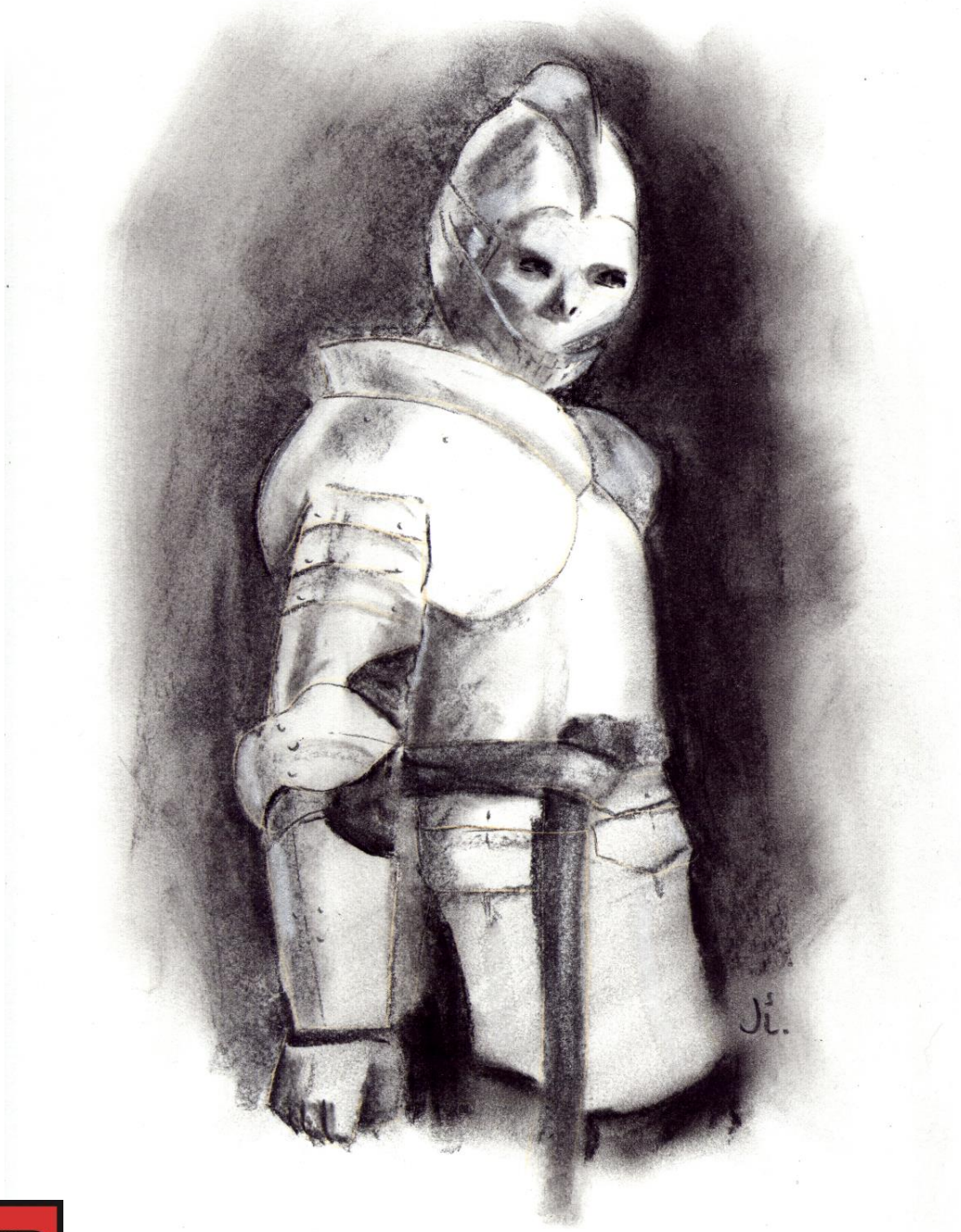
RISE OF THE ZHENTARIM

- Tales from the Swordcoast -

- A Sandbox Campaign for D&D 5th Edition -



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INTRODUCTION

The Year is 1491 DR. Times on the Swordcoast of Faerun are prosperous. The grand cities of the Lords' Alliance are growing, and trade is increasing. Unfortunately, this led to disputes and a falling out with the egalitarian and ecological factions, the Harper and the Emerald Enclave.
In the shadows, another faction also profits from the rise of the cities. The Zhentarim, its mercenary monopoly, and their more dubious lines of business flourish. Pereghost, the leader of the black network, seizes the opportunity. He plans to rebuild their former headquarters, Zhentil Keep, gather their mercenaries and build an army to overthrow all of Faerun.
Can the heroes unravel the plans of the Zhentarim, unite the factions and overthrow Pereghost in this epic campaign?



HOW TO RUN THIS CAMPAIGN?

The Rise of the Zhentarim is a sandbox campaign. You will use your own or third-party adventures to fill this campaign with life. Furthermore, you need to visualize most of the encounters of the main plot using maps and creatures, as you seem fit.

This work provides a prologue to introduce the heroes to the campaign's theme and an arc to follow on their heroic journey. You will also find tailored background information on the city of Neverwinter and the five involved factions. In the same chapter, you find an engaging method that describes how to integrate your own adventures into the thread of the campaign. Furthermore, I offer you the option of starting this campaign linearly and setting the heroes on their path using my three introductory adventures, which are purchasable at the DMs Guild.

Obviously, you can omit or change any of the ideas presented here to suit your playing style and the way your campaign is taking. It's a sandbox campaign. Make it your own!

And one more thing … I advise against telling the players the actual name of the campaign since it gives away some early plot developments. A more neutral title could be "Tales of the Sword Coast".



PROLOGUE

Supply the players with the prologue found on the following pages before the campaign starts and even before creating their characters. The report of the last faction meeting will inform them about the conflict between the factions and set the tone for the campaign.





Introductory Prologue

On a stormy winter day in the year 1488 in the Hall of Justice, Dagult Neverember slowly rose from his aged oak chair and walked to his gold-framed mirror. The Lord Protector of Neverwinter drove his hand through his dark and slightly silvered hair and adjusted the Lord's Alliance tunic. His gaze wandered up and down his imposing figure, and he lost himself in thought. "Only ten minutes left; I hope this meeting will not last until midnight again. Shadowmoon and Elminster are starting to get on my nerves. Who does this senile gaffer think he is anyway? He treats me like some apprentice of him … Oh well, let's get this over with."

Leaving his apartment, Dagult walked through the hallway of martyrdom. Luscious paintings of legendary priests of Tyr stared down on him until he entered the great hall, which could have served as a hoard of an ancient gold dragon. In its center, four simple clothed apprentices, standing in a circle, had already started the divination ritual. As Dagult took his place among them, they held up their hand and stepped back. Four flickering blue lights emerged out of nothingness right in front of them and took the ghostly shapes of humanoid holograms.

"Lanniver Strayl, Righteous Hand of the Order of the Gauntlet is present."

"Shadowmoon Crystalembers, Master of the Wild of the Emerald Enclave, is present."

"Evendur Greycastle, Viper of the Zhentarim is present."

"Elminster Aumar, High Harper is present."

"Lord Protector Dagult Neverember, Lioncrown of the Lords' Alliance is present … I welcome you all to our annual Factions of Faerun meeting. Are there any remarks before we begin with our first topic of the day?"

The wide brim of Elminsters wizard hat moved up a bit, and his eyes darted to Evendur Greycastle. "Didn't Pereghost send his pet dog to the last meeting as well? Does he not enjoy our company anymore?"

Evendur put on a perfectly bashful smile. "My deepest apologies Sir Aumar; my master is once more prevented from attending our gathering due to a tumult close to castle Darkhold. Of course, I will inform him of every detail of our discussions, and I am sure he is eager to receive them."

"I am sure he is," Elminster replied, slightly squinting one eye.

Dagult continued with his introduction, "Well, let us begin with the first topic - the rise of the cities of the Lords' Alliance. This topic was requested … once more … by Elminster Aurum, the High Harper, and Shadowmoon Crystalembers, Master of the Wild of the Emerald Enclave.

Allow me to start the debate… It is true that the cities of our Alliance prospered in the last century, except, of course, for the Jewel of the North. The catastrophe of Mount Hotenow still leaves deep scars in Neverwinter. We achieved this prosperity in Faerun mainly by increasing trade and securing the trade routes. We probably could not have done this without the help of our allies, the courageous members of the Order of the Gauntlet, who were always at our side when evil forces tried to destroy our flourishing civilization. The countless mercenaries of the Zhentarim help secure the trade as well, even though for a good price."

Lannifer and Evendur nodded their heads but did not interrupt.

"This achievement is truly a great one for Faerun. Our civilization advances into a new chapter, wealth and prosperity increase year by year. But as with any development, there are some slight side effects, which of course we will have to attend to."

"Some slight side effects?" interjected Shadowmoon from the Emerald Enclave. "The Cloakwood south of Baldurs Gate is being cut down for your houses, the Sword Mountains north of Waterdeep are being exploited for all the ore you can find, the river through Mirabar is getting polluted by dyers and tanners, and these are only a few of the so-called side effects of your civilization!"

"Well, I don't want to downplay your objection, but aren't these just some restricted regional consequences of the increased need for resources?" Dagult replied, half genuine, half aggravated.

Elminster took the word, "And what about the so-called wealth you mentioned, the wealth that brings power as it always does. I traveled the streets of the metropolis of Waterdeep last week. There are still countless beggars in the alleys and the crime rate increases. Sure, the mansions and residences are even more pompous than a few decades ago… Frankly, I don't see the often praised prosperity of the masses. I mainly see wealth and power amassed among a few."

"Surely it just needs some time that everyone participates in the newfound wealth. It won't be long till everyone can afford a good living." Dagult responded pacifyingly.

"Yes, yes, the usual empty words." Shadowmoon intervened, irritated. "So let's turn our attention to something more concrete, shall we? It was reported that two months ago, a druid circle in the center of Neverwinter Wood was attacked by some of your mercenaries."

"No, no, they were the ones being attacked. They were only protecting some lumberjacks and ferrymen."

"In the center of the wood? Is it not enough to weaken the balance of the forest by cutting away its borders? You have to slaughter the ancient trees in the heart of the wood?"

"There must have been some mistake," Dagult replied, increasingly nervous. "They must have misinterpreted the order."

Evendur of the Zhentarim, who listened attentively so far, took the word. "If my memory does not fool me, I still remember the order. Maybe I can help clarify the situation. Our mercenaries, who accompanied the loggers, were instructed to accompany them to the center of Neverwinter Wood and struck down any forces, which will prevent the loggers from carrying out their work."

"They were what?" screamed Shadowmoon. "This discussion is over! This charade of collaboration does nothing to prevent the natural world from destruction."

"I am afraid she is right," Elminster added, and both of them disappeared, leaving only a blueish haze at their places. Evendur vanished shortly after, leaving only Dagult and Lanniver standing side by side.

"That did not go too well now, did it?" Dagult sighted sarcastically.

"No, it didn't. You should have told them that we need the hardened wood of the forest's heart to construct a rampart against the spellplagued creatures still emerging from the Chasm of Neverwinter." Lanniver replied.

"Yes, probably, but there is no reasoning anymore once Shadowmoon loses her temper. Maybe it is for the better. I don't see a way out myself… Was your mission at Dragon Spear Castle successful? Can you return?"

"The forces of evil are still too strong south of the Dragon Spear. We cannot rebuild the southern Trade Way yet. I will inform you in detail when I am back in Neverwinter. See you soon, old friend."

"See you soon," Dagult answered with a tired smile and watched Lanniver vanish in a haze like the others. The Lord Protector had no time to dwell on the failed meeting. A lot of work awaited him if he was going to restore Neverwinter to its former glory.

The following summer, Lord Neverember managed to seal the Chasm of Neverwinter with the support of mercenaries from Mintarn, and the city is starting to flourish again. Despite his achievement, he could not hold on to the leadership of the Lords' Alliance. One of the Seven Sisters, the Open Lord of Warderdeep Laeral Silverhand, overtook his place. The annual meetings of the factions of Faerun did not continue, even with the change in guidance. Three years have passed, and we are writing the year 1491 DC.

THE ARC AND THE ACTS OF THE CAMPAIGN

The Arc of the Campaign

The Zhentarim secretly rise to power in the Sword Coast, mainly due to the centralization of the population in the growing cities of the Lords' Alliance. The increasing corruption, monopolization, and moral degradation of these mostly unregulated cities play into the hands of the black network. They have already bribed and occupied many high positions in the cities of the Alliance, and political opponents are getting kidnapped or assassinated.

The Zhentarim strive to dominate all of Faerun with their mercenary army. They are rebuilding the Zhentil Keep (SAG page 12) at the Moonsea and shielding it with the ancient guild artifact, the globe depicted below the dragon in the Zhentarim guild emblem. A powerful ally guards the artifact of the Zhentarim, the awakened *Kraken* in the ocean close to Neverwinter. The *Kraken* commands a few *aboleths*, of which one rules the lake beneath the closed chasm in Neverwinter. The *aboleth* enslaved and corrupted important figures of Neverwinter. It stays informed by consuming knowledgeable figures (MM page 14) of NW and the Swordcoast, brought to him by the Zhentarim.

The heroes discover the influence of the Zhentarim in Neverwinter. They need to unite the other four conflicted factions by becoming a guild member and advancing in renown and rank. During their missions for these virtuous factions, they are regularly confronted with the increasing corruption and menace of the black network.

Once the heroes advance to mid-level, they can confront the *aboleth*. By now, the heroes have discovered the connection between the *aboleth* and the *Kraken,* as well as the existence of the Zhentarim artifact. Furthermore, they learn about the other four ancient faction artifacts and are sent on missions to retain them. By recovering them, they further advance their ranks with the guilds and might gain leadership of the whole factions.

High-level heroes by now, they lead a special task force of faction members vs. the *Kraken* and discover the whole plan of the Zhentarim and their leader Pereghost. The Zhentarim, aware of the new threat, withdraw their mercenaries from all around Faerun to their reconstructed Zhentil Keep. This will cause turmoil in the now lesser-guarded cities of the Alliance. The heroes assemble a combined faction army. They travel to and charge the Zhentil Keep, disabling its spellshield protection with the Zhentarim artifact.

At last, the evil ambitions of the Zhentarim are put in place, and balance is restored.

Character Creation

Depending on your preferences as DM, you usually supply your players with none, some, or many guidelines and house rules to follow during their character creation. Running this campaign, there are two character background requirements, which would be helpful during the further cause of the campaign.

The first one is a standard guideline and only applies if you use my introductory adventures to set your players on their path. Since the first adventure hook is a mutual acquaintance/friend/relative, which has gone missing, the players need to work this into their background (chapter 7).

The second guideline is more invasive for the creation process. The heroes should choose one

of the four honorable factions from the get-go. They can either be an apprentice member or just sympathize with one of these factions. You may bait them with the faction advantages they can gain at higher ranks (chapter 6).
Furthermore, it would be helpful if they chose different factions. If the party is involved with various factions, the campaign will be more enthralling and create interesting dynamics and conflicts of choice.
As an alternative, they can also choose a faction later on, but from my personal experience running this campaign, that might feel a bit unfitting and forced for the players.

Act 1: Unravelling the Plans of the Zhentarim

The heroes start their adventures in the rejuvenating city of Neverwinter. You can find all relevant city details in chapter 5. There are different opportunities for gaining knowledge of the rising power of the Zhentarim. You can base your tier[1] 1 adventures around these developments and/or use them in the form of random encounters.

- Zhentarim mercenaries are gradually replacing the mercenary town guard of Neverwinter. They run an oppressive and corrupt reign over the city and seem to follow someone else's order.

- The crime rate in Neverwinter is skyrocketing. Behind it are thieves' guilds and other forms of organized crime run or supported by the black network.

- The Zhentarim members kidnap and feed well-informed enemies to the *aboleth* to increase his knowledge about the opposition of the Zhentarim. The introductory adventures use this hook as described in chapter 7.

After solving some of the problems caused by the black network and discovering that the Zhentarim faction is behind it, Lord Protector Dagult Neverember calls for them and offers the heroes Lords' Alliance missions.
The diplomat Evendur Greycastle frequently visits Neverember and tries to disguise the true dominance and ambitions of the Zhentarim for as long as possible. Furthermore, he persuades Dagult Neverember to strengthen the town guard with Zhentarim mercenaries.

Act 2: Advancing in Faction Ranks and Defeating the Aboleth

The heroes travel to the different factions and learn about the causes, which have led to the rise of the Zhentarim and the falling out of the honorable factions (chapter 6). The factions see the potential of the heroes and send them on various adventures of tier 1 and 2, which will advance them in renown and rank.

Either through the introductory adventures or other hooks, the heroes are already aware of the *aboleth*. Once they hit around level seven to eight, the Zhentarim mercenaries will kidnap Lord Protector Dagult himself to feed him to the *aboleth*. The heroes rescue him accompanied by a few elite members of the factions (chapter 6). Use the Sacrificial Pit Map from the Appendix for this encounter. After slaying the *aboleth* in his lair, they learn from one of his slaves that the monster was serving a *Kraken*.

[1] The tiers refer to the power level of chars as described in the DMG p.37 and PHB p. 15.

Furthermore, powerful necromancers of Neverwinter discover by reversing the *aboleth* telepathic abilities (see Gods in the Lake description - DMG page 14) that the *Kraken* wore a tiara holding the legendary artifact of the black network (chapter 6).

Act 3: Retrieving the Guild Artefacts and Defeating the Kraken

The four honorable factions are disturbed by this discovery and see the need to recover and retreat their own artifact (chapter 6). The heroes learn about their location and retrieve them in challenging adventures of tiers 2 and 3. Shortly after retreating the fourth artifact, the *Kraken* and its servants will attack Neverwinter and destroy parts of the city. Lord Protector Neverember will be among the casualties.

By now, the heroes hold a high rank among all or at least some of the good factions and will lead a task force of elite faction agents (chapter 6) against the *lair* of the *Kraken* and retreat the artifact of the Zhentarim.

Act 4: Defeating the Zhentarim

Pereghost, losing his artifact and starting to fear this new threat, will try to implement his plan. He will withdraw all mercenaries to the Zhentil Keep, which will lead to turmoil in the cities. The now weakened town guards will hardly be able to take control of the increasingly dangerous and corrupted cities. The only troops to spare are faction agents. The heroes, faction leaders, or at least legendary faction heroes by now, will gather a small army of faction agents and travel to the far east of Faerun to the Zhentil Keep. While the armies fight on the fields before the Keep, the heroes disable the spellshield of the Keep with the Zhentarim Globe (chapter 6). In an epic battle, they defeat Pereghost and his "mount", a black dragon.

Finally, the heroes warded off the threat of the Zhentarim domination and restored balance to Faerun.

NEVERWINTER - THE CITY OF SKILLED HANDS

For large parts, the campaign is set in Neverwinter, the seaport city on the northern Swordcoast of Faerun. In this chapter, you find handy infoboxes, which you can share with the players, as well as a random encounter table, which you can use to shake things up or further advance the main plot. Of course, you can use further information for the NPCs and locations mentioned here from sources like the Sword Coast Adventure Guide (SAG) or websites like https://forgottenrealms.fandom.com.

Try to make the city vibrant and atmospheric for the players.

The map used for the campaign is the city map drawn by Jared Blando, which can be found in the Sword Coast Adventure's Guide for example.

Neverwinter - City of Skilled Hands

The city has a troublesome past. Half a century ago, the volcano Mount Hotenow, northeast of Neverwinter, erupted. The magma stream reached the city and wounded it to the core. It left a deep chasm, which still covers large parts of the city. Soon after, plaguechanged creatures emerged from it, and the town guard evacuated the whole district and enclosed it by a rampart. After this catastrophe, different powers tried to get hold of the city's remains, including agents from the Hells themselves. Finally, a member of the Lords' Alliance, Dagult Neverember, took leadership and started to rebuild the city. He managed to seal the chasm, and the guard recently tore down the protective wall.

Nowadays, the city is in the early stages of resurgence, exciting times full of possibilities and dangers. New merchants, crafters, and guilds try to get a foothold every day, and no one knows who will hold influence and power a decade from now. Nevertheless, every inhabitant hopes that the city will return to its former glory, a beacon of craftsmanship, and to the City of Skilled Hands.

Neverwinter Guard

Lord Neverember installed a mercenary group from Mintarn, an independent island in the Sea of Swords after he took leadership of Neverwinter. The mercenaries serve as guards and army in one and take care of inner and outer threats. By now, they are accepted by most of the inhabitants, if only reluctantly, for bringing order back to the streets and pacifying the Chasm District. In the last year, members of the former oppositional rebel group, the Sons of Alagandor, and some volunteering new citizens joined the guard. The Mintarn forces are starting to get replaced step by step. This newly formed city guard calls themselves the Wintershield Watchmen.

The guard is led by the "tough as nails" general Sabine. Adventurers trying to help clean out some dangerous parts of the city negotiate with Sabine's right hand, sergeant Knox.

The Spellplague and Neverwinter

The Spellplague hit the whole planet of Toril a hundred years ago, from 1385 to 1395 DR. It originated in the death of Mystra at the hands of Cyric, the god of murder. Mystra was the goddess of Magic, and after her death, the Weave, which upholds the structure of all magic, was torn apart and corrupted. The whole earth was plunged into chaos for a decade, and the effects of the Spellplague are still present today, even though Mystra could be resurrected ten years ago.

In Neverwinter, the spellplague energy still affects a few buildings, namely the Castle Never, the Clock Tower, and the Fallen Tower, as well as the Moonstone Mask, which floats on a giant earthmote. Furthermore, the eruption of Mount Hotenow woke some buried forces and spellplagued creatures emerged from the chasm until the Lord Protector Dagult managed to seal it.

Neverwinter Districts and Points of Interest	
Bluelake District	The Bluelake District, formerly known as Blacklake District, used to be the area of the rich and noble. Even though the district survived the Mount Hotenow eruption rather well due to its location and the sturdy houses, the area is hard to recognize. Most survivors of the catastrophe fled to the Bluelake District, and the once luxurious residential quarters only hint at their former grandeur. Many of the survivors support the former royal family, the Alagondar. The most rebellious of the supporters call themselves the Sons of Alagondar. Only recently, their opposition against Lord Neverember eased a little bit, and a few of the nationalist group rebels even joined the town guard.
The Beached Leviathan	The Beached Leviathan is a three-decked inn and tavern located in the Bluelake District of Neverwinter that caters to sailors, smugglers, slavers, merchants, and others arriving by sea. It was built out of the refurbished wreckage of the pirate ship Leviathan. The one-legged pirate captain Harrag runs the tavern.
The Driftwood Tavern	The Driftwood Tavern is an upper-class inn and tavern. It survived the catastrophe nearly unscathed, and fine art and craftsmanship decorate the interior in every room, recalling the more glorious years of the City of Skilled Hands. It is run by the slow trusting, and conservative Madame Rosene. She is said to be a member of the Sons of Alagondar.
Castle Never	The awe-inspiring castle used to be the home of the royal Alagondar family. The entire royal family died during the eruption, and many of the delicate towers decorating the castle collapsed. Since then, the family haunts the castle as ghosts. Lord Neverember holds the ambition to reclaim the castle to cement his claim to the throne conclusively.
Tower District	The Tower District, also knowns as River District, was home to the middle-class inhabitants of Neverwinter before the eruption. After the catastrophe, orcs of the Many-Arrows tribe gained control of the area for decades. Lord Neverember drove the last of them away, and now the district is under control and repopulating by citizens again. Nevertheless, the influence of the orcs is still omnipresent, and many half-orcs roam the streets.
Shard of Night	The Shard of Night is the upper half of a wizard tower made of alabaster stone. The Shard is magically floating 100 feet high in the air. Its origin reaches over a hundred years back when it was broken and cast into the Shadowfell realm during an assault on Neverwinter. Its menacing aura was cleansed recently by Jasmine, a head-priestess of Selune, and the tower is often called Shard of the Moon now. Rumors tell that it holds the means of traveling over far distances in the blink of an eye.

The Fallen Tower	The Fallen Tower used to be the home of a great wizard centuries ago. He was overwhelmed by an assault but destroyed the tower with his final devastating spell. Since then, magical images of the battle flicker through the broken tower at midnight. It was reopened as a tavern frequented by humans and half-orcs alike.
The Clock Tower	The tower was under the control of wizards until a century ago. The Spellplague wiped them out, and only their cloaks remained. Thieves tried to plunder the tower, but the cloaks rose and slew every single one of the invaders. During the orc invasion, their leader somehow managed to overtake the tower, and it served as their headquarters until Lord Neverember drove them out.
Protector's Enclave	The Protector's Enclave combines three former districts, the Peninsula, the Market, and the City Core. The central marketplace, prison, and government buildings can be found here. It is named after Lord Protector Neverember, who moved here because the eruption of Mount Hotenow barely touched the district. The inhabitants of the Protector's Enclave are stern supporters of Neverember.
The House of Knowledge	The House of Knowledge was a tall and impressive temple of Oghma, which was severely damaged and is just starting to get repaired. After serving as the home of a devil cult for the last decade, the cult has been driven out, and priests of Oghma are arriving one by one to reclaim their former temple.
The Hall of Justice	A grand temple dedicated to Tyr. Lord Neverember used it as his seat of government until this year. Since more and more priests of Tyr return to the city, Neverember moved to his private, nearby villa and returned the temple to its followers. It now serves as headquarters of the Order of the Gauntlet in Neverwinter.
The Moonstone Mask	The Moonstone Mask is one of the most prestigious festival halls in the whole of Faerun. Since the Spellplague, it is floating on a giant earthmote, chained to piers, and can only be reached by a rope bridge. The hall is famous for its extravagance as well as its discretion. The whole staff wears moonstone-trimmed masks.
The Neverdeath Graveyard	The Spellplague heavily affected the graveyard, and various enemies of Neverwinter used the residual arcane energy to raise the dead and assault the city. Because of this, the inhabitants do not bury their dead in the graveyard anymore but burn and cremate them.

Neverwinter Random Encounter Table	
The table describes ten possible encounters the heroes can run across in Neverwinter, sorted according to their *challenge rating*. You can easily adjust the CR of the encounters by using different creatures. The encounters connected to the main Zhentarim plot are named accordingly. Furthermore, I added a town district to the title of the encounters, which should be run in a specific district.	
Dagult Neverember must go! - Bluelake District	Some of the remaining resistance against the Lord Protector Neverember assemble close to the Bluelake and demand his withdrawal. They fault him for his dubious claim to the Neverwinter throne due to his missing royal bloodline.
Zhentarim black market	The heroes stumble across a black market run by the Zhentarim. The market sells poison and other dubious wares.
Zhentarim thieves	A handful of *bandits* try to rob the heroes. If the heroes manage to interrogate them, they confess that they belong to a thieves' guild run by the Zhentarim.
Corrupt Zhentarim town guards	A few town *guards* are charging an unofficial toll for passing one of the three bridges in the city center. The heroes see a Zhentarim emblem on the necklet of one of the guards.
Oh no, not rats again!	*Giant rats* and a *swarm of rats* emerge from a nest in the sewers and overrun a food market.
Half-orcs up to no good! - Tower District	A couple of drunken *half-orcs* try to start a fight with the heroes after stumbling out of the Clock Tower tavern.
Zhentarim doppelganger	One of the NPCs, who works for the city, starts to behave strangely and gives orders, who advance the Zhentarim goal. The heroes might discover that he is a *doppelganger*, who killed the original NPC, and works for the enemy.
Dead but hungry! - Neverdeath	*Ghouls* emerge from a crypt at the Neverdeath Graveyard and start to feast on dug-out corpses.[1]
Spellplagued creatures - Chasm District	A few spellplague creatures emerge from an unnoticed crack in the sealed chasm and start to attack the new inhabitants on the district's border.
Zhentarim assassin	The black network gained knowledge of their new opposition and sent an *assassin* to deal with the heroes.

[1] You can run a whole undead quest at the Neverdeath Graveyard running my free adventure "The Mist of Horror" found at the DMs Guild.

THE FACTIONS

In this chapter, you find information on the factions, tailored to the campaign. This will help you create a well-rounded experience for your players. Starting the campaign, you should provide every player with the official WOTC infoboxes of the factions[2].

The Harpers: Leadership, Initiation and Relevant Members

In accord with their distrust of the concentration of power, a council of seven *High Harpers* leads the Harpers. Their unofficial main base is a tower complex in Berdusk, southeast of Baldur's Gate.

Any member who has reached at least the 2nd rank *Harpshadow* can recruit new members. The Initiates have to perform a valuable task for the faction to gain access. Upon initiation, they receive a silver harp emblem, a sign of recognition, which they shall not display openly.

Relevant members of the Harpers in order of their likely appearance during the campaign are Berrian Ganadolel, a bard in the beached leviathan, Renaer Neverember, the rebellious son of Lord Dagult Neverember, and Elminster, the living legend and one of the *High Harpers*.

Berrian Ganadolel

half-elf - chaotic good - *bard (VGM)*

Rank: Harpshadow of the Harpers

Appearance: Berrian has long blond hair, a strikingly beautiful face, and wears a long green robe, as depicted in the VGM on page 211. He is playing the lute.

Personality: He joined the Harpers because he scorns authority. Berrian is mostly interested in the pleasurable parts of life.

Quirk: He has a deep voice but often sings in falsetto and has already shattered a few of Harrag's wine glasses.

Secret: He will perform the *song of rest*, healing an extra 1d6 per short rest, for a harper and his allies.

Quote: "A fine wine and a warm bed shared with a lovely lady … why should anyone long for more?"

The Emerald Enclave: Leadership, Initiation and Relevant Members

The Emerald Enclave is led by the Elder Circle, consisting of three druids with the rank *Master of the Wild*. The main base of the faction is the House of Silvanas on the island of Ilighan in the Sea of Fallen Stars. Following the spellplague, the elven head of the Elder Circle Shadowmoon went insane, and the whole faction became radical and perverted in its pursuit of protecting the natural world. A decade

[2] https://dnd.wizards.com/dungeons-and-dragons/story/factions.

ago, Shadowmoon could be cured, and the faction is healing again as well.

Everyone who wanted to join the faction needed to travel to the House of Silvanas on a full moon for initiation. They also needed to be of neutral alignment. Since the rejuvenation of their leader and their whole faction, the Elder Circle allowed members holding at least the 3rd rank *Autumnreaver* to recruit others similarly across Faerun. Furthermore, members of good alignment are permitted as well, as long as they swear not to disregard the natural order for short-term human benefits. New members receive a piece of emerald green clothing and an oaken emblem of the stag as a sign of recognition.

If a member of the Emerald Enclave advances to the 4th rank of *Winterstalker*, he can choose between three paths called Circles. "The first, the Eldath Circle, sail the waterways of Faerûn, searching for knowledge and secrets beneath the waves that would benefit the Enclave. Second, the Circle of Alluvium walk the lands of Faerûn, observing for any unnatural forces that need to be put down and ensuring a peaceful existence between civilizations and the wilderness. Lastly, the Planar Circle pledged to watch for the most unnatural forces beyond the Material Plane. Many never return to the Material Plane but send word through other means while they keep their vigilance."[3]

Relevant Members of the Harpers in order of their likely appearance during the campaign are Lariel Wolfheart, a druid resident in the Neverwinter Wood, Delaan Winterhound, a ranger accompanied by a winter wolf, and Shadowmoon Crystalembers, the leader of the Elder Circle.

Lariel Wolfheart

wood elf - chaotic neutral - *druid*

Rank: Autumnreaver of the Emerald Enclave

Appearance: Slender but strong, gracile but not well-groomed at all. Lariel looks like she has been living with wolves.

Personality: Wary of strangers and civilization altogether, she lives purely for the natural world.

Quirk: Lariel howls when she is mourning.

Open Secret: Lariel was a foundling raised by wolves in the Neverwinter Wood. She still lives with her pack as the alpha wolf and is part of a local druid circle called the Ring of Swords.

Quote: "The wellbeing of my pack, the wellbeing of my forest, the well-being of civilization … that is the correct order."

Lords' Alliance: Leadership, Initiation and Relevant Members

As the name implies, the Lords' Alliance is a cooperation between over a dozen towns and cities as well as one island called Gundarlun. Although important decisions are reached collectively in arcane long-distance group meetings, the leader of their largest city Waterdeep presides over the faction. Dagult Neverember held this position a couple of years ago, but the wizard Laeral Silverhand supplanted him.

[3] Quote from https://forgottenrealms.fandom.com/wiki/Emerald_Enclave

There are many ways to serve the Lords' Alliance indirectly or as a member. Members of the third rank *Stingblade* can recruit others if they support the faction with outstanding services. These might be driving back threats from the city, fostering the trade between them, gaining a high-status position in a city court, or other deeds important for the Alliance.

Relevant Members of the Lords' Alliance are Alphonse Knox, the battle-scarred sergeant of the Neverwinter city guard, Dagult Neverember, the Lord Protector of Neverwinter, Taern Hornblade, the spokesperson and chief diplomat of Silverymoon and Laeral Silverhand, the Open Lord of Waterdeep and leader of the Alliance.

Sergeant Alphonse Knox

human - lawful good - *champion (VGM)*

Rank: Stingblade of the Lords' Alliance

Appearance: A black, bearded, muscular human in his fifties wearing an eyepatch and a Mohawk haircut.

Personality: Rough-edged but compassionate, Alphonse tries to do the right thing, cost what it may.

Quirk: His dwarven-forged greataxe never leaves his side. At night, he slides it under his bed.

Open Secret: A decade ago when undead hordes, led by an evil wizard, attacked Neverwinter. Alphonse slew dozens of them on the last defensive line, the Sleeping Dragon Bridge.

Quote: "You betray the city … you betray me!"

Open Lord of Neverwinter
Dagult Neverember

human - lawful neutral - *veteran*

Rank: Righteous Hand of the Lords' Alliance

Personality: Dagult is proud and charismatic but also manipulative and quick-tempered. No one knows for sure if he puts his ambitions or the goals of the Alliance first.

Appearance: Brown-haired, broad-shouldered and bearded … Dagult was often called a lion of a man.

Quirk: Interrupts everyone with a raised voice, who does not show him the respect he is due.

Open Secret: Many doubt his blood relationship with the former royal family Alagondar. Therefore, he rules as Open Lord and not as a king.

Quote: "I see great potential in you. Now, how can you help the city?"

The Order of the Gauntlet: Leadership, Initiation, and Relevant Members

Although the Order of the Gauntlet has a rank system, they do not have true leadership. The members of this relatively new faction gather in different places of Faerun, with the Neverwinter Hall of Justice being one of their core temples and headquarters.

Members of at least the third rank, *Whitehawk*, can recruit new members in a temple ceremony. The apprentices need to have fulfilled brave and good-hearted deeds, like defeating a pillaging orc tribe or an undead threat.

Relevant faction members are the faithful knight Lanniver Strayl and the orchard keeper and former adventurer Daran Eermath of Phandelver.

Knight Lanniver Strayl

human - lawful good - *champion*

Rank: Righteous Hand of the Order of the Gauntlet

Appearance: Brown-haired and blue-eyed, Lanniver looks like your next-door neighbor except for his shiny plate mail. Tyr's symbol, a scale on top of the mighty hammer, is engraved on the breastplate.

Personality: Talkative and idealistic through and through, Lanniver believes in a utopian world devoid of evil.

Quirk: He loses himself in enthusiastic, preachy monologues when he is talking about the beliefs and goals of his faction.

Open Secret: His squire (*knight*) Rhiele Vannis never leaves his side and hangs on every word of Lanniver.

Quote: "There is still a lot of darkness in this world, but if one by one we set a shining example for the world, the future will be bright."

The Zhentarim: Leadership, Initiation and Relevant Members

The Zhentarim, also called the black network, is led by Pereghost, a divine champion of Cyric. The headquarters of the faction is the Darkhold Castle in the Western Heartlands. During this campaign, they reclaim and rebuild their former stronghold and town, Zhentil Keep at the Sea of the Fallen Stars.
To join the 25.000 mercenaries of the black network, one has to be directly recruited by a member of rank *Viper* or higher. The Zhentarim are expanding in other, shadier businesses, like becoming patrons of thieves' guilds to foster their rise. Many thieves, black market traders, assassins, and other scoundrels support the Zhentarim without being official members.

Relevant Members of the Zhentarim in order of their appearance in the campaign are the diplomat Evendur Greycastle, the Beholder Ralakor, and the Dread Lord Pereghost.

Diplomat Evendur Greycastle

human - neutral evil - *noble*

Rank: Viper of the Zhentarim

Appearance: Evendur belongs to the Chondathan ethnic group. He is slender, tawny-skinned, with brown hair and green eyes. He wears a silk robe in the colors of the Zhentarim emblem and the dragon symbol on a chain around his neck.

Personality: Slick and charismatic as well as unscrupulous and opportunistic, Evendur knows how to play one side against the other in this game of diplomacy.

Quirk: He talks and moves so incredibly smoothly that one cannot help but delight in listening to him.

Secret: Evendur wears an invisible *Ring of Mind Shielding*.

Quote: "I am the last to refute that the Zhentarim had a dubious reputation in the past. But isn't it about time to bury those old grudged and cooperate for the greater good … for the progress of our great civilization of Faerun?"

Commander Pereghost

human - chaotic evil - *blackguard (VGM)*

Rank: Dread Lord of the Zhentarim

Appearance: No one knows the true appearance of Pereghost, as he is only seen in his chalk-white plate armor. His helmet resembles a human skull.

Personality: Pereghost used to be a lawful villain but is embracing the chaos more and more.

Quirk: He enjoys killing victims single-handedly by breaking their necks or throwing them to death.

Secret: As is known only among the Zhentarim, Pereghost changed his alignment, becoming a champion of Cyric, the god of murder. Unknown even among his factions, his ultimate goal changed as well, from securing the domination of the Zhentarim to throwing the whole Faerun into a realm of chaos.

Quote: "Exploit allies, deceit strong foes and kill the weak … this is easy!"

Background Information Provided by the Factions

The four righteous factions are not only crucial for supporting the heroes with warriors and eventually a whole army but also for supplying them with background information for the campaign plot. Provide them with the following knowledge, as you seem fit. The players should already know most of it from the prologue.

The Harpers mention that the cities and their elites grew stronger and stronger over the last century. The power and wealth between the classes increase, and the crime rate with it.

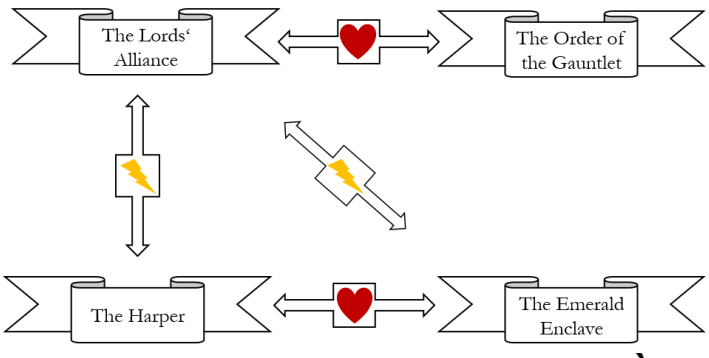
The Emerald Enclave explains that the cities grew too large and disturbed the natural balance over the last century. The enclave is starting to oppose the forces of the civilization (again) and sees its only ally in the Harper faction.

The Lords' Alliance conveys to the heroes that the relationship between the factions deteriorates. They do not have contact with the Harpers and the Emerald Enclave anymore.
Furthermore, the heroes are informed that crime rates are rising in different cities of the Alliance.

The Order of the Gauntlet encourages them to investigate and strike against the Zhentarim with their support as soon as they find and deliver proof.

The Relationship between the Factions

The relationships of the factions are illustrated in the following diagram.



The Harper and the Emerald Enclave are critical of the city growth and the power monopolization in the cities of the Lords' Alliance. This opposition strengthens the bond between them.
The Order of the Gauntlet sees the Alliance as a force for good and welcomes their flourishing over the last decades. They regularly cooperate with them, striking against mutual foes.

Earning Renown and Faction Rewards

Most adventures you integrate into this sandbox campaign should be offered by one of the factions. In addition to the experience they gain and the magic items they find, the heroes are rewarded by acquiring *renown* with the corresponding faction (DMG page 22). Only the hero, who is a member of the relevant faction, will gain *renown* equal to his level upon completion of the task. This increasing *renown* rewarded by the tasks throughout the campaign reflects the growing challenge and the significance for the factions. I will demonstrate the *renown* system in a short example. A level 3 hero, who is a member of the Emerald Enclave and just saved a forest from pillaging orcs in an adventure offered by the Enclave, will earn 3 renown and advance at least to rank 2.
The highest rank 5 and therefore the leadership over the whole faction can only be acquired by gaining 50 *renown* as well as retrieving the faction artifact described in the next chapter.

Gaining higher ranks in a faction will unlock rewards for the heroes and therefore offer additional extrinsic motivation to work for them and follow the arc of the campaign. They can access free lodging, mounts, and can even gain authority over comrade at arms. Gaining leadership of the whole faction will also enable the hero to lead the corresponding army against the Zhentarim in the campaign showdown.

Faction Rewards			
	Free Lodging	Mount	Authority
Rank 1 / Renown 1	Modest		
Rank 2 / Renown 3	Comfor-table	Riding mount	
Rank 3 / Renown 10	Wealthy	Chain mail barding	Comrade in arms
Rank 4 / Renown 25	Aristocrat	Flying mount	Taskforce
Rank 5 / Renown 50	A noble estate	Mithril barding	Faction army

Supply the heroes with the Infobox of the faction rewards. The comrade in arms will only accompany the heroes in missions critical for the faction, meaning only the battles described in chapter 2, like the fight against the *aboleth* or the *Kraken*.
You can find the titles of the faction ranks in the DMG on page 22.

The Faction Artifacts

Every faction member has heard myths about those powerful items, but they have been lost for so many generations that even the oldest members are unsure if they ever existed. However, once the heroes have gained knowledge of the *Kraken* and the Zhentarim artifact described in chapter 2 - act 3, the factions conclude that the other four must exist as well and decide that they need to retrieve them. The heroes, highly reputed among their factions by now, are ordered to research and recover the long-lost

artifacts. They might gain detailed knowledge of them in great libraries like Candlekeep or any other way you choose.

The heroes find out that the five founders of each of the factions created the artifacts and that they are depicted in every corresponding banner. Two of these artifacts, the Harp and the Orb of Dragons, are described in detail on the following pages. You can design the others by using the DMG guidelines from page 219. Use the official faction banner as a visual depiction of the artifacts.

Faction	Artifact
The Harpers	The Harp of the Moon
Emerald Enclave	The Emerald Diadem[4]
Lord's Alliance	The Crown of the Lords
Order of the Gauntlet	The Sword of Justice
The Zhentarim	The Orb of Dragons

According to the forgotten knowledge, only members of the highest renown can wield the artifact. The Zhentarim artifact is an exception to this. It can be wielded by everyone but will drive most unworthy ones into madness, as mentioned in the description.

Furthermore, any member of highest renown, who is attuned to an artifact and wields it, has a claim to the faction's leadership. Except for Pereghost of the Zhentarim, every leader accepts this claim. The heroes might also let this possibility of leadership pass by and concentrate on their tasks as heroes, but one way or the other, they have enough influence by this point to direct the whole forces of their faction.

[4] The Diadem can not be seen in the banner, but the artifact sprouts spiritual antlers upon use as depicted.

The Harp of the Moon

Artifact of the Harpers (requires *attunement* and rank 5 in the Harper faction), *wondrous item*

The Harp is about two feet high and carved out of a dark brown mysterious wood. The strings seem to be made out of focused moonlight and sparkle while being played. The harp has to be wielded with two hands.

Random Properties:
Two *minor* and one *major beneficial property* (DMG page 219). Reroll any property above a dice result of 50.

Harp Proficiency:
Everyone *attuned* to the Harp gains *proficiency* in this musical instrument for the time his attunement lasts.

Increased AC and Saving Throws:
While playing the Harp, the wielder gains +2 AC and +2 to all *saving throws*.

Spell Focus:
The Harp functions as a *spell focus* for all classes. Furthermore, the *somatic components* of each spell can be omitted, allowing the wielder to cast all non-*concentration* spells while playing.

Songs of the Moon:
The Wielder can play one of the following seven instrumental songs as a *bonus action* while wielding the Harp. Playing a song requires *concentration*. The spell's casting time is reduced to a *bonus action*, the *duration* of the effects is limited to the time you play, and all *components* are omitted. If the song requires a saving throw from any creature, the *spell save DC* of the wielder is used.

- Song of Calm Emotion: The song functions as the spell *calm emotions* centered on yourself.
- Song of Truth: The song functions as the spell *zone of truth* centered on yourself.
- Song of Fear: The song functions as the spell *fear* with the differences, that it only afflicts enemies, and that the area effect is a circle with 30 feet radius centered on yourself.
- Song of Tongues: The song functions as the spell *tongues* with the difference that it affects all creatures in a circle with a 30 feet radius centered on yourself.
- Song of Confusion: The song functions as the spell *confusion* with the differences, that it only afflicts enemies and that the area affected is a circle with 30 feet radius centered on yourself.
- Song of Freedom: The song functions as the spell *freedom of movement* with the difference that it only afflicts allies and that the area affected is a circle with 30 feet radius centered on yourself.
- Awakening Song: The song functions as the spell *awaken*.

Destroying the Harp:
Only the fire breath of an *ancient red dragon* can scorch the wooden artifact.

The Orb of Dragons

Artifact of the Zhentarim (requires *attunement*), *wondrous item*

The Orb is a perfect sphere of unbreakable glass measuring five inches in diameter. Inside, black and beige, chaotic winds twirl around each other.

Random Properties:
Two *minor* and one *major beneficial property* (page 219 DMG).

Curse:
Anyone wielding the artifact, who is not of evil alignment and highest *renown* among the Zhentarim, might succumb to madness using its summoning power as described below.

Summoning Powers:
The Orb holds daily and monthly usable summoning powers.

- Daily:
  Once per long rest, the wielder can summon a shadow *wyvern*. The casting time is one minute, and the duration is 24 hours. No *concentration* to uphold the spell is needed. The shadow *wyvern* retains its *wyvern* statistics except for the shadow traits described in the Monster Manual on page 85. The *shadow breath* feature is replaced by *shadow stinger*, meaning the attack deals necromantic instead of poison damage. The shadow *wyvern* can serve as a mount.
  If the wielder is not of evil alignment and highest *renown* among the Zhentarim, he must pass a DC 15 *charisma check* after the summoning is complete. On a failed *check,* he succumbs to a *long-term madness* (page 260 DMG).

- Monthly:
  Once per month, the wielder can summon a young red *shadow dragon* (page 95 MM). The casting time is ten minutes, and the duration is 24 hours. No *concentration* to uphold the spell is needed. If the wielder is not of evil alignment and highest *renown* among the Zhentarim, he must pass a DC 15 *charisma check* after the summoning is complete. On a failed *check*, he succumbs to an *indefinite madness* (page 260 DMG).

Destroying the Orb:
Only the fire breath of an *ancient gold dragon* can melt the glass artifact.

How to Get Started - the Introductory Adventures

You can plan and improvise your way to get the campaign rolling, or you can use my adventure trilogy of the Hole in Wall Gang sold on the DMs Guild. The three adventures are called "Demon Cult Monastery", "Treasure Hunt", and "Taking on the Hole in Wall Gang". The adventures are written as standalone quests for any setting, but they are also designed to introduce the threat of the Zhentarim for this campaign step by step. All adventures use the DMG maps found at the end of the book.
Below you find additional background information on integrating the adventure trilogy into this campaign.

Hole in the Wall Gang - What happened so far?

Shaena's upcoming thieves' guild, the Hole in Wall Gang, is part of the growing black Zhentarim network. Recently they kidnapped the half-elf diplomat and member of the Lords' Alliance Immeral Brightwood, who just arrived from Silverymoon, and fed him to the *aboleth* in the Neverwinter chasm. Immeral wanted to report and discuss the increased crimes in Silverymoon and their connection to the black network - still unknown in Neverwinter - as well as debate possible actions of the Lord's Alliance.

The Hole in Wall Gang - First Contact

The heroes want to investigate the disappearance of Immeral for their own reasons, which they should work out in the characters' backstories. Immeral wanted to meet with all heroes partly because of their personal relationship and partly because he wanted to discuss his troubling messages with members of all four virtuous factions. Even though the heroes probably do not know each other yet, he invited them all for the same time to the Driftwood Tavern before he traveled to Neverwinter.

Read out the following introduction to the first session to set the heroes on their path.

> *"You have been waiting in the Driftwood Tavern in the Bluelake District of Neverwinter for quite some time now. As you discuss among yourselves, none of you know Immeral as unreliable or even unpunctual. Talking to the owner Madame Rosene, you find out that he rented a room here yesterday but never showed up.*
> *After finishing your hearty meal, you decide to take things into your own hands, and you head to the town guard hall in the Protectors Enclave. The one-eyed Sergeant Knox informs you that they have more than enough on their hands with keeping order in the city and cannot spare any guards for a case of a missing half-elf. However, he assumes that one of the newly formed thieves' guild might be involved in his disappearing and tells you that they are known to recruit new members in the Beached Leviathan tavern at the harbor."*

The heroes head to the Beached Leviathan and the epic quest begins. Continue with reading out the Infobox of the Beached Leviathan found in the adventure "Demon Cult Monastery" and run it for the players! The next subchapter follows up on the developments from the adventure.

The Hole in Wall Gang - Recruitment

Mickey Blueeyes has led the heroes to a back alley close to the house of Shaena Underbough, the leader of the upcoming Hole in the Wall thieves' guild. You can find the map of the house, which

plays a larger part in the third and last introductive adventure, on page 310 in the DMG.
Shaena, leaning on a wall in the alley, welcomes the heroes and starts to negotiate. She still does not reveal the location of her house and the hideout of the thieves' guild underneath it.

Shaena Underbough

halfling - chaotic evil - *bandit captain*

Appearance: A halfling with short curly red hair and a scar across her freckled cheek

Personality: Adorable, excitable and ruthless, all to the same degree; Shanea is quite a deadly mixture.

Quirk: She talks fast and jumps from one foot to the other when she gets enthusiastic.

Secret: She is fascinated with all kinds of magic even though she is not talented enough to master it.

Quote: "You think magicians don't reveal their secrets … well just let me have a talk with them."

Shaena was not counting on the success of the inexperienced heroes but conceals her surprise. She offers the heroes a membership in the guild for the lowest ranks called Knife if they fulfill one more task for her.
Their job is to obtain a booty chest from a pirate ship. Shaenas contacts found out that an overly confident, married pirate couple and a few crew-members did not return a captured treasure chest to their leader, none other than the Third High Captain Dagmaer Suljack of Luskan. Instead, they sailed south and lie at anchor this night in a bay just northwest of the city walls[5].
The booty chest has to be locked when the heroes deliver it to Shaena, and they will split the loot among themselves.

The quest continues. Run the adventure "Treasure Hunt" at this point!

The Hole in the Wall Gang - Gaining Access to Their Hide-Out

Bringing the treasure back to the ship and returning to the Beached Leviathan is a challenge in itself. Back at the tavern, Mickey Blueeyes will reveal the location of Shaena's house. It is located in the same alley in the Bluelake District, in which Shanae met them before the adventure. She will enthusiastically greet them at the door, lead them to the negotiation room, unlock the chest with ease, and split the content.
Afterward, she will fetch some dark grey robes from upstairs. On closer inspection, the robes are marked with a double-stitched hole on the bottom side of the right sleeve. Shaena tells them they have to wear the robes all the time and shows them their secret greeting ritual - moving the right arm to the side and presenting the guild hole. The heroes become guild members, carry the rank of Knife, and gain 200 group XP for infiltrating the guild.

Knives get access to the hideout beneath the house. You can find the map in the DMG on page 311. They can use the hideout to find a safe haven, communicate with other guild members, or shop at the black market. See the Appendix for goods offered. Furthermore, Shanea sends them on jobs regularly. The obligations are simple, they cannot

[5] If you use Jared Blandos Neverwinter map, you can find the small bay in the northwest behind the tiny islands.

turn down a task, or the guild will blacklist them, which equals a death sentence for most.

The Hole in the Wall Gang - Discovering the Fate of Immeral Brightwood

Unfortunately, Immeral, imprisoned in the hide-out, has already been dragged and fed to the *aboleth*. Still, the heroes discover that the Zhentarim are behind the crime and find an unlikely ally in the last introductory adventure.

There are two ways to run this adventure. If the heroes confront Shaena right away in her house, she will try to flee through the basement and the cellar system to her chambers while ordering the guild members to fight them off.
The heroes can also enter the cellar system freely after becoming members of the Hole in the Wall Gang and explore the rooms untroubled. Ultimately, they will have to confront the guild to enter the prison cells, where Immeral was kept, and fight their way out.

The quest resolves. Run the adventure "Taking on the Hole in the Wall Gang" at this point!

WHERE TO GO FROM HERE?

Finishing the introductory adventures or creating your own start, the heroes should now be on their path. They are involved with one of the virtuous factions and have a personal agenda to gain influence and reconcile the factions, in order to expose and confront the Zhentarim with their combined help.
The heroes should be motivated by themselves or nudged a little to visit their factions, which will offer them the missions to advance in *renown* and rank. This is where the sandbox aspect of the campaign comes into play. Use your adventure collection[6] or improvise your own to create an open world for the players, which gives them the feeling of freedom and choice. You can always lead them back to the main arc of the campaign, as you seem fit.

It's a sandbox campaign. Make it your own!

[6] You can add my free adventure "The Mist of Horror" to your collection right now, which you can easily connect to any of the four factions. It serves as a well-balanced follow up to the introductory adventures.

APPENDIX

Black-Market Goods

The heroes can buy the following from the Hole in the Wall gang member Beido in area 3 of their hideout.

- Adventuring gear:
  Acid, alchemist's fire, antitoxin, ball bearings, caltrops, climber's kit, crowbar, grappling hook, hunting trap, bullseye lantern, hooded lantern, lock, steel mirror, basic poison, hempen rope, iron spikes, spyglass, torch, vial or a complete burglars pack

- Tools:
  Disguise kit, dice set, playing card set, poisoner's kit, and thieves' tools

- Armor and Weapons:
  Leather and *studded leather armor, dagger, light crossbow, dart, shortbow, longbow, rapier, scimitar,* and *shortsword*

- Barakas also sells one scroll of *mage hand* for 25 GP and a magic *dagger +1* for 250 gold.

Beido Shady-Eye

half-elf - chaotic neutral - *commoner*

Appearance: A lank and elderly half-elf with silver hair and one blank eye.

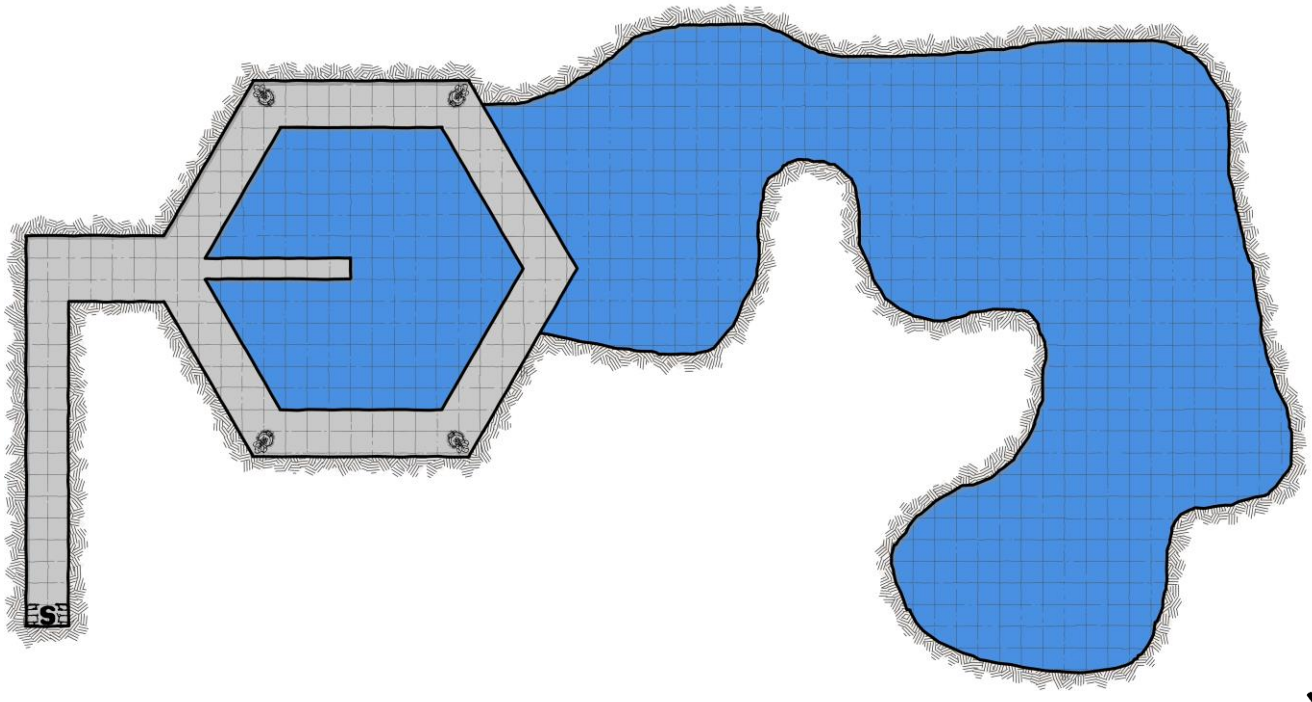
Personality: Fatalistic and almost bored to death, Beido does not get emotionally evolved in anything.

Quirk: He often loses interest in the mundane customers and stares right through them.

Secret: He was the illegitimate son of an elven princess of Silverymoon and an adventurer. He was never accepted on the elven court.

Quote: "Life is short? Seems to me it takes forever."

Sacrificial Pit Map



Official WOTC Resources Used

Neverwinter: The city map of the artist Jared Blando used in the SAG on page 52 is used here and is recommended for running the game.

Abbreviations

DMG - Dungeon Master's Guide
MM - Monster Manual
SAG - Sword Coast Adventure's Guide
VGM - Volos Guide to Monsters

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Body of Work

As of 2022, my DMs Guild collected works consist of five adventures based on the DMG maps and one free sandbox campaign stringing them all together. Furthermore, I wrote a Norse campaign, including maps and a world compendium a few years ago, which you can purchase on DriveThruRPG. In the following years, I will write adventures for the lair maps found in the Volos Guide to Monsters.

Links

Newsletter:

https://362e9dee.sibforms.com/serve/MUIEAM12zkTk3bv5lDM2ymDTBjCfS0fWljVyF3Nk5091jmnZUcyDb1OjD7fzJGCP18Jp4T3axw4C0y7q0x-GqZ-6B60CMpV8V01ryRUM4yuQoTSub9kQ8zB4R-82trb3l9msS8gJRCSuVgrRVaVnIkoexuZnLfQtfgsKOs-x0HcVTmCcbs9vtzjMcpXnD-1VLZJOrLViYsJy7pbk

Discord Channel:

https://discord.gg/GqE6ZzasVG

DMs Guild Works:

https://www.dmsguild.com/browse.php?author=Bj%C3%B6rn%20Karsten%20Wendisch

DriveThruRPG Works:

https://www.drivethrurpg.com/browse/pub/10393/Bjrn-Karsten-Wendisch

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- JSLArtShop, found on Etsy, illustrated the cover art.
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